

Court upholds ban on ‘ghost guns’

Justices agree that homemade weapons qualify as firearms under federal law.

By David G. Savage

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court on Wednesday upheld a federal restriction on the sale of parts kits that permit unlicensed gun owners to make firearms at home that cannot be traced by the police.

In a 7-2 decision, the justices agreed these homemade weapons, often referred to as “ghost guns,” qualify as firearms under federal law.

“Today, thousands of law-enforcement agencies nationwide depend on the [federal] tracing system to link firearms involved in crimes to their owners,” said Justice Neil M. Gorsuch for the court.

Justices Clarence Thomas and Samuel A. Alito Jr. dissented.

The decision upholds a regulation issued in 2022 by the Biden administration that was strongly supported by police and prosecutors.

The ruling overturns conservative judges in Texas who said Congress had not given federal regulators the power to outlaw “parts kits” that could be assembled into a weapon.

It’s a rare win for gun control advocates in the high court.

“This Supreme Court decision is great news for everyone but the criminals who have adopted untraceable ghost guns as their weapons of choice,” said John Feinblatt, president of [See Guns, A5]



ADAM SPIEGEL, founder of the small-batch whiskey distillery Sonoma Distilling Co., stands in front of his 3,000-gallon pot still. “Trying to forecast with this level of uncertainty is very difficult,” Spiegel said.

California’s alcohol industry may drown in a trade war

Tariffs deepen existential crisis for importers, exporters, retailers

By Andrea Chang

Back in December, alcohol importer Raza Zaidi in San Francisco placed an order for a pallet of gins, liqueurs and bitters from a Mexican spirits producer.

As the truck made its way north toward the border several weeks later, it was up against the clock: On Feb. 1, President Trump had announced plans to impose 25% tariffs on imports from Mexico and Canada.

Those levies went into effect March 4 — the day Zaidi’s pallet of 1,000 bottles arrived at the port of entry in Laredo, Texas. But in a reversal two days later, Trump said he would temporarily lift the tariffs on many Mexican and Canadian goods for a month.

The rapid back-and-forth caused confusion at the border crossing, Zaidi said, as customs authorities figured out how to assess shipments [See Tariffs, A9]



A BOTTLE of whiskey from Sonoma Distilling, which is struggling to determine how much production and packaging can be done.



A WORKER loads cars onto a vehicle transport truck in Richmond, Calif., on Wednesday. President Trump said he would implement a tariff on auto imports.

Trump places 25% tariff on automobile imports

White House argues domestic production will grow. Prices are likely to increase too.

By Josh Boak

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Wednesday he was placing a 25% tariff on auto imports, a move that the White House claims

would foster domestic manufacturing but could also put a financial squeeze on automakers that depend on global supply chains.

“This will continue to spur growth,” Trump told reporters. “We’ll effectively be charging a 25% tariff.”

The tariffs, which the White House expects to raise \$100 billion in revenue annually, could be complicated as even U.S. automakers source their

components from around the world.

The tax hike starting in April means automakers could face higher costs and lower sales, though Trump argues that the tariffs will lead to more factories opening in the United States and the end of what he judges to be a “ridiculous” supply chain in which auto parts and finished vehicles are manufactured across the [See Tariffs, A6]

Rebuilding begins after fires despite lack of soil testing

FEMA decision puts entire communities at risk of toxic exposure, state lawmakers assert.

By Tony Briscoe

In Altadena and the Pacific Palisades neighborhood of L.A., reconstruction has begun despite the fact that the soil on affected properties has not been tested for toxic substances.

The Federal Emergency Management Agency’s controversial decision to forgo soil testing in communities burned in the Eaton and Palisades wildfires sparked pushback Wednesday as California lawmakers questioned whether the practice will prevent residents from knowing if there are toxic substances on the land before rebuilding begins.

Federally hired cleanup crews have been removing ash and debris, in addition to a 6-inch layer of topsoil, from buildings burned by the wildfires. But, asked last month by The Times, FEMA and the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers confirmed they won’t test the soil at these

properties after they finish their cleanup, breaking with a long-standing practice that was intended to ensure that homes and schools don’t still contain excessive levels of harmful chemicals after environmental disasters such as a wildfire.

Led by U.S. Rep. Laura Friedman (D-Glendale), a contingent of eight federal lawmakers from California objected to FEMA’s decision to forgo soil testing in a letter to Cameron Hamilton, the agency’s acting administrator. The lawmakers pressed Hamilton to explain the change in strategy. One key question was how FEMA could ensure that removing 6 inches of soil would be sufficient to rid properties of toxic substances.

“The residents of greater Los Angeles should be informed of any potential toxins in the soil as they navigate the complicated recovery process,” the letter reads. “Wildfire survivors deserve to return to safe, toxin-free properties.”

The Eaton and Palisades wildfires — among the most destructive in California history — damaged or destroyed more than 13,500 [See Rebuilding, A7]

HEGSETH FACING GROWING CALLS TO RESIGN

Democrats want the Defense secretary and others to step down after security breach.

By Faith E. Pinho and Kevin Rector

WASHINGTON — Democrats escalated their calls Wednesday for top Trump administration officials to resign or be fired for their part in a stunning national security breach, after the Atlantic published more of the detailed military strike plans those officials discussed on the Signal messaging app.

President Trump and several top officials on that text chain — including Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, CIA Director John Ratcliffe and Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard — had spent much of Tuesday downplaying the security breach, suggesting the information shared was not classified.

Hegseth and other White House officials — including Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt — had gone so far as to suggest the whole thing was a “hoax” spread by Atlantic Editor in Chief Jeffrey Goldberg, who had inadvertently been included in the chat and broke the story Monday.

But on Wednesday, Goldberg and Atlantic reporter Shane Harris published a second article, which included the portions of the chat Goldberg had previously withheld showing the military attack plans that Hegseth had shared with the 18-member group. Those plans detailed the weapon systems, timing and sequence of strikes on Houthi targets in Yemen, hours before they occurred.

“Just CONFIRMED w/ CENTCOM we are a GO for mission launch,” Hegseth wrote, referring to Central Command, the military’s Middle East combatant command, the Atlantic reported.

“1215et: F-18s LAUNCH (1st strike package),” the [See Signal, A5]

D.A. lifts hold on death penalty

L.A. County’s Hochman moves to undo predecessor’s policy that barred seeking it. CALIFORNIA, B1

Inside bumpy Paramount sale

The federal government’s review of the \$8-billion deal could stretch into the summer. BUSINESS, A8

Party drug is no laughing matter

Nitrous oxide may be popular in the music scene, but it’s risky. L.A. might ban sales. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather

Low clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 66/53. B6

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